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Marty Sheller

Marty Sheller is frequently cited as an architect of Latin Soul. After a notable career as a trumpet player with Mongo Santamaria, he became a sought-after arranger/composer for major Latin jazz artists, most notably with Fania Records.

Marty was interviewed via Zoom on May 9, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and boy am I pleased to have Marty Sheller with me today. Mr. Sheller, welcome, and congratulations on your career.

MS: Thank you very much, Monk.

MR: It's been a long and fruitful one, and I can see behind you at the keyboard and music placed in various spots, that you're still at it?

MS: Oh yes.

MR: Can you tell me, I was going to ask this later but I'm going to go for it now. If you're in the mood to write something original, or you get a request or a commission for something brand new, is there a way that you get started on that?

MS: Yes. It'll be either thinking of what rhythm I want to use and then a bass line that implies some chords, and we go from there.

MR: I'm smiling because I have to have a bass line myself.

MS: Yep. It's interesting how, starting from scratch that bass line indicates certain chords, or, it's funny that the melody usually comes a little further down the line. The rhythm and the bass line come first.

MR: Are you sitting in front of the keyboard when you do that?

MS: Yes.

MR: And I wonder, if you're anything like me, do musical — once you get started do musical ideas to add to it come into your head when you're away from the keyboard?

MS: Yes. I have a piece of manuscript paper at the side of my bed for those moments where I'll just — usually it comes from my listening to an album, someone's album that I'm interested in, and somewhere during the course of that I'll say to myself, "Gee that's kind of nice, I think I'd like to write something in that groove."

MR: And you have the ability to write down what you're hearing in your head fairly accurately?

MS: Fairly accurately, yes. That's sort of like the basis. Once I get to the keyboard I embellish on that, and that's how different chords and different voicings come into play.

MR: Yeah, speaking of voicing, I've been listening to a few cuts of the Marty Sheller Ensemble. And I'm wondering what is the minimal or the sweet spot for you as far as number of horn players?

MS: That's a rough question. As you can tell, my own albums used five horns: two trumpets, trombone, alto sax and tenor sax. And the reason I chose that is because I can get a small group feeling and a larger group feeling out of the same instrumentation and there are some spots where even people have mentioned, they say, "Boy it sounds like a big band." And other spots where I know I want it to be a smaller sound so I'll have, let's say especially behind a soloist, instead of having all the other horns play behind a soloist, I'll just choose two let's say, and have them play behind the soloist.

MR: That seems like something that takes a while to learn, that not having everybody play all the time is an arranging technique. I guess less is more applies.

MS: Yeah. Well you know I never studied arranging formally. I studied, I was a trumpet player and the trumpet teachers that I had were very proud of the fact that I became a very good sight reader and I was able to play with good technique. But as far as arranging was concerned, that was a matter of my good luck and being involved with some very good musicians, and also using my ear to determine what kind of things I wanted to write. Plus I was very lucky in the early stages. I was doing a lot of writing for a company called Fania Records, which was like the Latin Motown. And the vast majority of those arrangements were being recorded and as a result I can listen to the recordings and I learned certain things did not sound as good as I thought that they were going to, and there were others that sounded a little better than I thought they were going to. And in between those things and also whenever I was at a — either at a gig or a recording session, everyone warms up and when the piano player would warm up and I would hear him play something that I really liked but that I wasn't able to duplicate, I would go over to him and ask him, "What was that that you just played?" and get a piece of paper and write out five lines real quick and take it home and work on it and work on it so that became part of my vocabulary as well.

MR: Oh, that's a great story. Were you usually in the studio when bands were playing your charts?

MS: Yes. With Fania in particular, they wanted the arrangers to be there to quote make sure your arrangements sounded good and by the way, not pay you for even being in the studio to conduct.

MR: I see.

MS: They'd pay for the arrangement but not for the conducting. But that was their policy.

MR: Yeah, like it's not our fault if something doesn't sound quite the way —

MR: Did you ever have to run out into the main room with a pencil and you heard a note that — ah that's not what I want.

MS: Yep, yep. That's right.

MR: The process of — back to your original composition — do you ever have eight bars of something that's been sitting around and you're working on something and say boy this, it's time for the bridge. And, oh yeah there's this thing sitting over there that I did before. Have you ever pasted things together?

MS: Very perceptive. Yes. That is true. Being exactly that situation. I'm usually — I usually don't have things sitting around, but every now and then there are some things that I'll start working on and for some reason not get back to it. I've got one right now that's on the keyboard that I've got eight bars that I'm not sure exactly where I'm going to go with it and it's been sitting there for a while and there's a perfect example of somewhere down the line I might look at that again at a certain spot that I am in another arrangement, and look at it and say, "Gee, that would kind of fit there." So I would alter the key to make sure that it was in the right key, but yes, that happens occasionally.

MR: For me the hardest part is usually coming up with a form and a chord sequence that's not the twelve bar blues or something. And I wonder how do you go about finding an interesting and worthwhile set of changes?

MS: Well most of the time I do write in either 16-bar phrases or, for Latin music it can be, you know 4-bar phrases or 8-bar phrases. There have been a few things that I've written that are in not the standard 4/4, 6/8 kind of rhythm. I generally don't write in those rhythms but every now and then there's an inspiration. I remember in particular writing a piece of a great percussionist Giovanni Hidalgo that was in 5/4, but it was — the melody statement was 5/4 but there was a little interlude that was in 4/4, and then back to 5/4. Where generally I'm a 4/4, 6/8, 12/8 kind of guy.

MR: How do you charge for arrangements? Is there a union scale, sort of a minimum that you're supposed to get and as you became more well known could your price for your charts adjust accordingly?

MS: Yes. There is a minimum scale and as time went by and I started getting more recognition, and to be honest the work I was doing — better work — I was more pleased with what I was doing. It got to a point where now when someone calls about an arrangement I'll ask about the instrumentation, get as much information as I can from them, and then determine about how long it's going to take me, which by the way I'm not one of those fast arrangers. It takes me some time. And then I just say well my price will be, and that's the way I get to the price.

MR: How often do people say, oh boy that's not what I had in mind?

MS: Well I'll tell you that has happened in my earlier stages. I'll tell you the story of what would happen. I would give them a price, they would say exactly that, "Well you know the record company's only paying X amount and they're not going to go for your price." So my answer was, "Well sorry about that, maybe we can work again in the future." And I would say maybe, 95 percent of the time somewhere down the line, a week later or a few days later or so I'd get a call and they would say well we found a way to figure it out, we're going to put in a certain amount from our pocket so between that and the record company we'll give you your price.

MR: Oh that's good business practice.

MS: Yeah. And I also found out that, yeah, I don't want to mention the names but it was a record company where they were paying a certain price for all arrangements and I felt that it was time for me to get a little more money and I spoke to the fellow who was the person in charge of that, and I said well I'm sorry I can't do it unless I get that price. And he said to me, "Okay I'll give you that price but don't tell any of the other arrangers." So naturally, you know arrangers are my friends. So the first thing I did I got home and I called them up and I said, "Hey listen, the next arrangement you have, ask for this amount because they gave it to me. You don't have to mention my name but insist on that."

MR: Yeah there has to be camaraderie in musicians.

MS: Oh yeah, oh yeah.

MR: The hard part can be titles. When you're writing an original tune when does the title come along?

MS: Good question. I never think of a title before I start to write. I know certain composers will get an idea about I don't know, look out the window and see a beautiful scene and say that reminds me of the time I went to Acapulco so I'm going to write something that would be appropriate for that. I'm the opposite. I write strictly by the notes and the chords and the harmonies. And when I get to the end I say now what am I going to call this? And it's the truth. I'm terrible with that. I mean I can't even remember one time of me, well one time I might have wanted to write something for my wife and I wrote something that I felt would be appropriate. But other than that, titles are a problem with me.

MR: Yes. I know what you're saying and I remember Bela Fleck, the wonderful banjo player said that he just kept a list of titles. He'd see a word, "Well that could be a song," and next time he needed one he'd look at the list.

MS: There you go. I can understand that.

MR: Yeah. What about, with your own ensemble over the years, have you ever had occasion where you wanted not to tell the soloist how to play, but give them some direction so that their improvisations sort of jived with the nature of the composition?

MS: Not that I can remember. It's usually a case, especially with my own recordings where I have such faith in the musicianship of the players that I'm anxious to hear how they approach it and just you know, the first rehearsal everybody's just getting notes under their fingers. The second rehearsal they're starting to get a little more familiar with it. Third rehearsal they start playing the hell out of it. And that's how I look at it. And even with other arrangements for other groups I generally don't give a direction of a — especially for the soloist — of what to do. That's kind of, how shall I say, can't think of the right term but heretical or to ask them to play it a certain way, after they put their own ideas toward it.

MR: That's true, in fact that's why you chose them in the first place because you had faith in what they might do with it I assume.

MS: Yeah. And I was very pleased by the way, with the CDs that I recorded, they were actually recorded all at the same time and at that point I really had no intention of releasing a CD I just wanted to do some music that I felt proud of and that I could send copies to some friends. And the fellas in the band started telling me, "Man it's too good to just leave it there, you ought to put out a CD." So I had two CDs worth of music that I had recorded over the course of maybe a week or two. And I said well it's hard to pick what I'm going to put on the CD so I'll just go with different rhythmic grooves and have a variety and that's how I chose the songs for the first CD and then ten years later everybody — you know the guys got on me again. They said, "You know you've got all of these other songs, don't let them lay there." So that became the second CD.

MR: There's one tune, "Time Will Tell" and you got two grooves in one song for that one. I really enjoyed that one.

MS: Uh huh.

MR: Yeah it had that sort of 12/8 part and then there's this — I have this own sort of barometer about tunes. And if a tune ends and I can't hum something back or some rhythm or some melodic phrase, then it doesn't really pass muster for me. And when I listen to some of your original work I said well these things, as soon as this thing is over I'm going to be able to hum this part back. Like there's a little lick in "Time Will Tell" it starts on beat 3 — it's like one, two [scats]. It's so hip and it just like is only one part of the composition. So I guess what I'm saying is well done.

MS: Thank you. Thank you very much.

MR: I want to take you back a little bit. You grew up in Newark, is that correct?

MR: Do you recall, let's say you're 12, 13, 14. What music made a lasting impression with you?

MS: It began with the West Coast players, a group of friends that I had that we used to get together and play, we were listening to the guys out of the West Coast: Shorty Rogers and Stan Kenton, those kind of people. And I've thought about that and I realize that the reason probably was it was easier to understand. And matter of fact, when I went to high school one of the fellas in my high school was a very good tenor saxophone player and he laid a Miles Davis record on me and it was "Blue 'N' Boogie," one of those extended 45s part 1 and part 2. The musician's name was Buddy Terry, and he gave it to me. I took it home and I listened to it and, Monk, it went right over my head. I just didn't understand what was going on because I had been listening, like I said, to the West Coast players. So I just put it in with the rest of my music and it sat there for about a year, a year and a half. And when I got into high school I just happened to cull through my record collection again and I listened to it. And bing! It hit me. I like sort of said how could I have fallen asleep on this record? And that led me to try and investigate some of the players that were on it, and I was lucky enough to have gone to a famous old jazz club called The Café Bohemia with a double bill, catch this double bill — there was the Art Blakey Quintet and the Max Roach Quintet. Now my friend and I walked in at the last number of Max Roach's Quintet which was a beautiful "Valse Hot." That was with Sonny Rollins and Kenny Dorham. And that knocked me out, the idea that they could swing so hard in 3/4. When they got off the stand Art Blakey came on and that was being some of the hardest bop ever, that was with Jackie McLean on alto and Bill Hardman on trumpet, and I was so impressed — oh and plus the stage at the Café Bohemia was very high, like maybe five feet high, and at the end of the set, which was the end of the night, Blakey sat on the edge of the stage with his legs dangling over and he gave his famous "Support Jazz" speech. And I was so impressed. So when I walked outside I looked up at the marquee and I said I'm not familiar with these guys. I wrote down the names and that started my collection of the East Coast players.

MR: Terrific story. I remember that Café Bohemia is mentioned in Cannonball Adderley's entrance into the jazz world also.

MS: Yes.

MR: So then you go up and you end up playing in a band in the Catskills.

MS: Right. A Latin band.

MR: What kind, sorry, again?

MS: A Latin band.

MR: A Latin band.

MS: Yes. A very small Latin band. It was just timbales, piano, bass, and trumpet. No conga, no other Latin percussion. And as a matter of fact the timbale player, every one of the timbale players were influenced by Tito Puente. And I heard the timbale player play some of these licks that to me were new, and I thought this guy is a genius. Listen to these hip things that he's playing. It was actually Tito Puente licks. But that was my introduction to Latin music.

MR: This seems very interesting to me. This would have been mid-60s?

MS: No earlier than that. I'll tell you when — the summer of '58 I played up in the Catskills but that was a different, that was a little Jewish hotel with a great band, four of us, three guys from Columbia College, my dear friend Bobby Porcelli, a great alto player, my friend Myron Schwartzman a piano player, and I can't recall the name of the drummer. But that was the summer of '58. The summer of '59 is when that gig that I was talking about came up in the Catskills. I think it was at Young's Gap Hotel.

MR: Young's Gap?

MS: Yeah.

MR: Okay. Well I've got this vision of 1958 and in the early evening you're playing —

MS: I was 19.

MR: Maybe, you're 19, you're playing like "Night Train" or "Spanish Eyes" and then you guys go back and listen to hard bop?

MS: No actually that Latin gig we weren't playing "Night Train," we were playing the Latin songs. Tito Puente arrangements but pared down to that small quartet group.

MR: That's very — was the music, obviously then that kind of music was popular enough that it got booked into a Catskills club. I guess this is an education for me, that that Latin music was popular enough for it to be a summer band.

MS: Oh absolutely. As a matter of fact all of the larger hotels had big — Machito's band played a summer in the Concord Hotel, Puente's band played a summer, I can't recall the name of the hotel, but you know these were — the instrumentation was the same instrumentation that they used when they played at the Palladium. But there was a big Jewish community that loved Latin music and they were the people who would vacation in the Catskills, so there would be an American band that would play American music and for the shows, and the Latin band that was the Latin band.

MR: What did you learn in that band and subsequent groups from watching the dancers?

MS: Oh, right away I could pick out, I loved watching the dancers, then you can pick out — the more I learned about the music, the more I recognized what made a good dancer. And there were some that were obviously really sharp and that was a pleasure. I had the pleasure of playing at the Palladium many times and the dancers were terrific. And it's

everybody feels it. You know how that is? Even though people don't know what it is, they feel it. They know that something's going on. They may not know what it is but they're aware that something is going on. And the dancers would respond. The best dancers were the ones who were listening to the rhythms and would respond. Because there's a history of African music where there were just drums and dancers. And that was carried on to Cuba and from Cuba to the United States. And there were some terrific dancers. As a matter of fact I think it was like Wednesday night at the Palladium was a special night for the dancers. And there were stories about how Marlon Brando used to hang out there. It became like the hip place to be you know.

MR: Was it odd, later on, when a group like Mongo Santamaria, Tito Puente, if you put that group in Town Hall, at a sit down concert, did it change the music because there was no room for dancing? Now the audience is sitting and listening.

MS: It didn't change the music, but you could tell if the music was happening by people moving in their seats and occasionally getting up and being told by the ushers, sit down, you can't do that here. We played, we did play a gig with Mongo's band — I'm trying to think of where it was — a relatively well known concert hall. And the sound was terrible because they're used to putting one microphone up in front of the orchestra, you know, the classical orchestra, and they balance themselves and they sound great. But in a band where you've got three percussionists that all play loud, you've got a timbale player, a conga player and a bongo player who also plays cowbell. It doesn't work. So if they would put one microphone for them, naturally someone's going to get lost in the mix. Same with the horns. If there's one for the horns, someone's going to get lost in the mix. So in those places, although prestigious, were not the best places to play.

MR: Yeah that's a great way for a brass player to blow their chops trying to play over the — I don't know if there's any such thing as a pianissimo timbale.

MS: No. And you're right about brass players. It was a struggle. As a matter of fact nowadays I see how everybody's got a microphone. You know those clip on mics that they have for the horns and all? So you get a good soundman who gets a good sound balance on it, you can hear everything clearly. That's a pleasure. But although I should say that there was some great big band recordings done with, for example I remember being at one session, I didn't play on it but I was lucky enough to be there, Machito's band recorded in a huge hall, it was a dance hall but in the daytime they would set up mics. And the way they would do it is the four trumpet players would set up in a circle and put a mic in the middle. The five sax players would set up in a circle and put a mic in the middle. And the producer, who is back in the booth, when they would do a test would say, "We need a little more alto sax" that meant moving your seat a little closer. Or, "We need a little less,

make that adjustment. But some of those albums sound great to this day, they really sound terrific. So technology offers the ability to do a lot of things that couldn't be done, but that's not to say that it's better.

MR: That's a memorable statement. I mean I remember stories of Louis Armstrong had to move way back to the other end of the recording — the room where they were playing into a megaphone, right?

MS: Yeah, yeah. It was a famous Latin vocalist named Yayo El Indio who had one of those voices. And when the singers would overdub the chorus parts they were also in a circle and Yayo was always told, "Stand back two steps" because he just had one of those voices that cut through.

MR: You mentioned the Miles Davis that you put away for a year and then you got it out again and you literally had a "bing." Did you have to have a bing with absorbing the Latin rhythms and sort of getting it inside you?

MS: In a way yes. 'Cause that first gig that I mentioned to you where it was just a quartet playing Tito Puente arrangements, I couldn't understand at the very beginning in Latin music the bass player does not play on the one, and that's all the music I ever heard, the bass always played on the one. But on Latin music they play on the one and — one two three four one two boom bing, boom boom. That kind of rhythm. And I remember playing the first couple of songs and I was really thrown off, I was reading the music but trying to figure out how come what I was playing was in 4/4 but that didn't sound like what the bass was playing. As soon as that hooked up, that was a milestone for me. Because then I started to appreciate that that was also what the conga player was playing on, and that's what the clave was all about. So slowly but surely I started finding out those things as a result. I was very lucky, you know, Monk, that my introduction to the real deal of Latin music was brought about by two wonderful musicians. One was a conga player named Frankie Malabé, and one was a timbale player/arranger named Louie Ramirez. And Frankie would have me come to his house. He knew that I liked Latin music. I knew that he liked jazz. So he would come to my house and we would put on my collection and listen to that. When I went to his house, he lived on Simpson Street, which was, you know the famous Fort Apache Precinct, well that was on Simpson Street. It was across the street, about six, seven houses down. And I would go to his house, his father-in-law was a great cook by the way, he used to have rice and beans, he always had it for me. The main thing is I appreciated good food. And what Frankie would do is he would set up two chairs facing each other and we would be knee to knee. And he would play music, Latin music, and play on my knees what he would play as a conga player, and explain why. With Louie Ramirez, Louie was a great arranger. So just by playing in his

that was my introduction to that end of the music. And like I said, I was always asking questions to make sure I knew exactly that I was getting the real deal, and I was lucky enough to have had those two fellas as my teachers.

MR: Yeah you couldn't pay for that kind of thing in a music school I don't think.

MS: Right. That's right.

MR: Wow. Were your parents supportive of this solidifying of a career in music?

MS: Not at all. Not at all. I was — after high school I was accepted to Columbia College, and they were looking for some kind of profession, preferably a lawyer, something like that. And after my first summer at Columbia, which was the summer of '58, it was like an epiphany. I said boy this is what I've got to do. And when they heard that they were not very pleased at all. It took quite a while before they started to realize that it looks like he can make some money doing this. Because I have a vivid recollection of one night at the Village Gate, which was a place that used to have Latin music and jazz music on a 6-day week gig, and I was lucky enough, I was playing with Mongo's band at the time. It would be — the show would be Mongo's band and Thelonious Monk's quartet. Or Mongo's band and the Horace Silver quintet. And the sound man and the light man — who was the same guy — really liked the band and really got to know the music and there was one song in particular that ended abruptly and oh I left out that I had invited my mother and father to come to the show that night. And Mongo was very, very popular in New York. And I got them really good seats and we played this number that ended abruptly and as soon as it hit that last bop the lights went off and it was very theatrical. And the audience went crazy applauding, demanding an encore. And the alto player in the band, Bobby Capers, leaned over to me and he said, "Marty, isn't that your mom standing on the chair over there?" 'Cause she was a shorty. She was like five foot one, and she was up there yelling with everybody else. "More, more." So at that point I think they realized that maybe I could do okay in the music business. They would have preferred not but that's what I chose.

MR: Thank you for that. That's a terrific story. What was it like to, you must have been in the musician's union eventually.

MS: Yes.

MR: And if you're looking for work you go down to the musician's union hall and like hang?

MS: Yes. Well I don't know how it is now but because I live in Delaware, I'm out of that scene. But it used to be every Monday, Wednesday and Friday afternoon the dance hall that was called Roseland had a — you know it was a big dance hall — that's where the musicians would come and look for gigs. And at that time all the Latin bands had trumpet players. And when you walked in the entrance the jazz musicians used to hang out on the

date musicians hung out on the main dance floor. And every now and then someone from the Latin section needed a trumpet player so the word would filter over to the jazz section, where I used to hang out, and I got plenty of gigs that way, also developed a reputation because I was able to sight read very well and I could solo. So like I said, I got a lot of gigs that way.

MR: What was the average price, the average bread that you might make on, I guess we could describe that as a pick-up gig?

MS: In those days? $25. $30. Something like that.

MR: And did you get that money in cash?

MS: Yes.

MR: Okay. So you didn't have to pay a union fee on that as long as you were paying your dues.

MS: Yes.

MR: Okay.

MS: I wish, as a matter of fact, if all of the gigs that I played, including some with Mongo's band and all the recordings that I did that I conducted afterwards, if all of that went to the union I would have a pension and a half. But most of them did not go through the union. But you know I was in it for the music and that's what counted.

MR: Good statement. So you've been involved in a couple of really terrific recordings with Mongo and I wanted to ask a specific question about the "Watermelon Man" and you know I've read about how that sort of came about.

MS: Okay.

MR: But the terrific thing that the horns did. Instead of playing [scats] they went [scats].

MS: Yup.

MR: How did that occur?

MS: Well I have to take credit for that one.

MR: Go right ahead.

MS: I was the one. I don't know whether you read the story Herbie Hancock has told how it got to Mongo. Herbie had recorded "Watermelon Man" I think around the summer of '92. And somewhere down the line Mongo was doing — oh I remember — Mongo was playing a gig in a little club in the Bronx and Chick Corea was the pianist but Chick had already given notice a long time ago that he wasn't going to be available for that gig and Mongo was at Symphony Sid's office and Donald Byrd was there. And when Donald Byrd heard that Mongo needed a piano player for Friday, Saturday and Sunday, he said that, "If you're hung up for a piano player, I know a piano player, a great piano player. He reads really well. I doubt whether he's ever played in a Latin band but if you need

Hancock." So Herbie played that gig Friday, Saturday and Sunday, and Donald Byrd came to the gig one of those nights and Donald, Herbie Hancock and Mongo were talking about the influence of Latin and Cuban music on funk music. And Donald Byrd said to Herbie Hancock, "Play that little vamp 'Watermelon Man.'" So Herbie played "Watermelon Man" and Mongo really liked it, told him to come by rehearsal, new rehearsals starting on Monday, which is the first rehearsal that I made with the band. And we played "Watermelon Man." We rehearsed it that week and did a gig on the weekend at a club in Brooklyn and played "Watermelon Man," the people were going crazy. And when it came to playing the melody I thought of somehow, a guy who was going to sing, "hey watermelon man" is not going to be going [scats] he's going to be a [scats]. So he started phrasing it that way. And matter of fact an interesting story, after it became a hit Mongo asked Herbie if he had another song similar to that, something, another funk kind of a song. So Herbie said yeah, and he brought by a song called "Cantaloupe Island." And we rehearsed it a couple of times and then Herbie left the rehearsal and Mongo said, "Naaa. I think I'll pass on this one." Little did he know — so we never got to record that.

MR: Yeah.

MS: If we did we would have been the first ones to have recorded it.

MR: Yeah lightning didn't strike twice for Mongo on that one.

MS: Right. Right.

MR: I really also, this is pretty minute I guess, but when you get to the last [scats] the horn players, you guys did this wonderful sort of like hesitation [scats].

MS: Right.

MR: You almost feel like oh no the dancers are going to fall down. But you know of course one comes back in where it's supposed to.

MS: Yeah. I'm not sure exactly how that came about but I think the three horn players, which were me, Bobby Capers on alto and Hubert Laws on tenor, just somehow decided hey let's do that. I think there's no other explanation I can think of.

MR: So your trumpet solo is so perfect for the song. Do you recall thinking I'm going to keep my bop chops in check sort of? And play these cool riffs because this is what the song requires?

MS: Nope. The story is, there was a record at that time by Barbara — oh son of a gun I can't recall her name —

MR: Barbara George.

MS: That's it. There was a terrific cornet player named Melvin Lastie who played a trumpet solo on that, that ended with [scats]. So when we got in to do the recording of "Watermelon Man" we approached it like a jazz-funk song. So there was a trumpet solo

"Wait a minute. For airplay it's got to be like three minutes or so. We've got to shorten it. So I want you to cut out the sax solo, cut out the piano solo," he said, "and Marty, don't play any of those snakes." Now snakes were what he called jazz lines that moved up and down. He said, "Just play something funky." And right off the tip of my tongue I said, "Oh you mean something like this" and I played Melvin Lastie's [scats]. He said, "Yes! That's it. Play a solo like that." And that's how that came about. As a matter of fact, Melvin found out that — I hadn't met him at that point — but he found out that I had always given him credit whenever anyone asked about that solo because it seems as if that solo became popular. And I always gave him credit. And he's from New Orleans. When he finally came to New York he came up to the apartment right across from the hall where I was, because his friend Idris Muhammed, the drummer, was living right across the hall and Idris said, "Hey man, Marty Sheller lives right next door." And Melvin wanted to say hello. So we gave each other a big hug and he told me, he said, "Man I appreciate it that you always gave me credit for that."

MR: Aww. That makes my heart full, man. That's terrific. Were you expected — I remember reading that Illinois Jacquet would play some of those solos and then people wanted to hear the solo as recorded.

MS: I hear where you're going. You're touching a nerve.

MR: Yeah.

MS: Mongo said the same thing. He said, "Marty, that solo, you've got to play that solo." I said, "Mongo, you mean you want me to play this every time we play 'Watermelon Man' I've got to play the same solo?" He said, "Yes, it's very popular. You've got to do it." Boy that's — what's the — can't think of the right term, but that got me nuts. You know I did that every time we played it I had to play that solo. And it got a good reaction too, so I understood why he wanted that, but you know how it is from the point of view of somebody who's into improvising, the idea of playing a solo exactly the same way rubbed me the wrong way. But that's the way it was.

MR: Wow. So let me see if I can vocalize this rhythm — tell me what other Mongo song this is? [scats]

MS: Bossa nova.

MR: Yeah. I'm thinking of "Yeh Yeh."

MS: Right.

MR: So it was almost a clave rhythm.

MS: It's exactly the bossa nova clave rhythm.

MR: Okay.

MS: That was composed by Pat Patrick and Rodgers Grant. I'm not sure — I think Pat might

moving up. But that became pretty popular. There was a guy Georgie Fame in England who I understand had a pretty nice hit with that song. A vocal version.

MR: He did indeed with lyrics by Jon Hendricks I think.

MS: Yeah.

MR: Now were you in on the original — you were in the band at that time?

MS: Yes.

MR: Yeah. There's some really cool horn harmonies. Is that something Patrick wrote out?

MS: That's a good question, I'm not sure who did. Either he or Rodgers. I'm not sure which one.

MR: Some of them are so — they're not experimental they're just things that you wouldn't go for first. I'm not even sure how to describe it, but there's this lick near the end where the one horn is going [scats] and this other horn is going [scats].

MS: Yeah. Like I said I'm not sure which one of those fellas wrote that.

MR: Well it sure does stick in your head, I'll say that much.

MS: Yeah. Yeah. When you mentioned Jon Hendricks, that brings a story to mind again about Mongo. I had written a song called "Cuidado" which means be careful, and it was an uptempo mambo, a jazz mambo, written basically on bebop kind of chords. And Mongo was with Columbia at that time. And somehow Jon Hendricks wrote lyrics to my solo that I played on that. And we were going into the studio to record so Mongo said, "Hey Jon, come to the studio and record that, it sounds great. It'll be a great selling point." So he came into the studio, put him in a booth, and boy did he sound good. He really sounded terrific. So Mongo said, "Great, that'll be on the record." Jon said, "No, no, no. I can do a much better version. That was just the scratch version." Mongo said, "No, no, I mean it's great." And Jon insisted no, that it was just temporary. So Jon got an advance from Columbia Records, which I'm not sure what it was but I'm sure it must have been a nice taste. He still had a great reputation at that point and all. And Jon disappeared. He moved to Europe and we never had an opportunity to do it. And it was always in my mind and Mongo said the same thing, that he didn't — it sounded so good, what he had written — and you know the way he was he was like very particular about doing it right, about using the right syllables and putting lyrics to it. And he did a great job, but we never had an opportunity to record it with him. Who knows whatever happened to that tape.

MR: The lost Jon Hendricks.

MS: Yeah.

MR: When you were with Fania Records, did they have, I'm reading a quote here. I think it may have come from your website, but I'm going to read it. It said, "The name salsa

Fania Records as a catchy marketing label. Salsa is often thought of as a Latin essence as the word soul has been a description for black American essence."

MS: Very good. Whoever wrote that hit the nail on the head.

MR: So combining Latin and soul music, I'm trying to form a question about how deliberate, as an arranger, you're thinking here's the Latin, all these Latin grooves, and over here we've got this soul feel and you're sitting writing a chart, how do you grab that? How do you combine Latin and soul?

MS: Well generally as I recall they were two different things. When I wrote a Latin arrangement I was thinking strictly Latin, using jazz harmonies in some places to spice it up, but not thinking about soul music. There were some bands, like Mongo, there was another fellow named Pucho who also recorded funky kind of things with a Latin rhythm section and in those cases yes, that was thinking in a funky soulful kind of way. But I never, it wasn't something that I would combine. Each one was sort of like its own — it was important to do it authentically.

MR: I guess Herbie Hancock's vamp on "Watermelon Man" is a good example of it.

MS: Sure. Sure. Absolutely. Absolutely.

MR: I'm fascinated sometimes why a 3-2 clave is played instead of a 2-3 clave. Can you enlighten me?

MS: Okay. Once the song starts the clave never changes. The phrase changes. And I'll give you a good example. Let me — I've got to — here we go. Remember that advertisement for Chiquita Banana [sings] Chiquita Banana and I come to say? Okay. You're going to notice at the end of that phrase I'm going to be clapping the clave. The clave doesn't change but the phrase changes. [scats and claps] Three two. Two three. See what I mean?

MR: I do.

MS: And once the clave begins it never changes. It's the phrase that changes, that goes along with the clave.

MR: Thank you, Marty.

MS: Yeah. Yeah.

MR: That's how I needed it to be explained.

MS: Yeah. And by the way, that also, the clave is the basis of how the conga player plays, because he'll play two three [scats] boom boom. That boom boom is on the one, two, three. [Scats] So it all hooks up.

MR: It all hooks up. I used to have a job booking groups for public school performances and one year we had this marvelous Latin band from Albany, Alex Torres and the Latin Kings. And they had the three percussionists and horns and piano and I remember getting, I guess aggravated with myself because they would get going and I would lose

MS: Yeah.

MR: I can't find one.

MS: That's not unusual. That's a common thing for people who are not raised in that culture and are used to hearing it all the time, the same way somebody in a Latin community would listen to a blues and not know where does it start? Well you know where it starts because you can hear where it starts. But they're not used to hearing it that way. So that's not an uncommon thing. Like I said, when I first started learning about it, boy that bass part really threw me off and I had the same question, where is the one? As a matter of fact guys made little jokes about it 'cause some have written songs, "Where's the One." You know when you get deeper into the rhythms and you get into the Cuban group, there's a group called [Los] Muñuquitos de Matanzas, which is just a drums and vocal group, that's all. Just a bunch of drummers, all conga players, maybe someone playing the cowbell. When you hear that you can get lost easily. Where is the one? When you want to go deeper than that you get into more African rhythms where again, you know, you can be surprised, where is the one? How come I lost it, I was following it so carefully. But it's really just a matter of listening and listening. Like I said the fellow Frankie Malabé who was an inspiration to me, was the one who took me down that road of starting me off listening to Tito Puente and Tito Rodriguez and Machito, because he knew that I could understand where the beat was and what was going on. Then we'd go a little bit deeper into the drumming and voices groups and after I thought that I had it down listening to Puente and Machito, all of a sudden I was back to square one. Where's the one? So that's a very interesting journey to take.

MR: Was your work as an arranger and music director subject to the whims of popular music over the years? Or was the Latin music community a more level playing field?

MS: Well I would say the Latin and the jazz community — I'm not, it's just not something, the pop music field is not something that I'm particularly interested in.

MR: How about the Miami —

MS: There's some very good music being recorded that way, but that's not in my heart.

MR: Would a group like the Miami Sound Machine pass your litmus test as far as Latin music?

MS: That, yes. They've got their own thing, the Latin music. I'm a little more, one of the bands that I don't know whether it fits in this category but that I loved was Earth, Wind and Fire and Sly and the Family Stone. But as far as that being in Florida, they do play Latin music. It's not completely authentic because there are a lot of pop touches in it, but they are a really good band.

MR: I'd like to run a couple of names by you and see if you have anything that you might

MS: An old friend. A great trumpet player, really great trumpet player. He recorded a couple of things that I composed and a really good friend. We've known each other — as a matter of fact I met him that second year that I played up in the Catskills, he was in the American band. Yeah. Really nice guy. Kind-hearted fellow, and like I said, a hell of a trumpet player.

MR: He did some great work with Blood, Sweat & Tears of course.

MS: Oh yeah. And with Gil Evans also. And he did a lot of recordings on his own.

MR: How about Dave Valentin?

MS: Yes. Dave was a great flutist and with a terrific sense of humor. It was a pleasure. We used to meet at recording sessions. And one of the sessions that I mentioned to you where I wrote some music for Giovanni Hidalgo. He was the kind of a guy, what they did is they put tape inside my earphones that I wasn't aware of, and I put them on and I said, "You know I don't hear things too clearly." And everybody cracked up. That's when I knew something had happened and I took off the earphones and there was this tape. Dave Valentin. He was another really great musician. It's a shame that he was taken so young.

MR: I see David Byrne as someone listed that you've worked with.

MS: That was just a matter of horn overdubs. He'd already recorded the tracks and he wanted me to write some overdubs on some of them.

MR: And so he would send you the recording?

MS: Yeah he would send me the track, everything that was there besides what I was going to write.

MR: How has your relationship been with producers over the years?

MS: Pretty good because generally they respect my abilities and they respect my comments and suggestions. So I haven't had any problems. Like maybe I just haven't run into the wrong kind of people, but it's pretty good.

MR: I think I read something about when Mongo's band got signed to Columbia, that Mitch Miller assigned a producer that didn't quite get it.

MS: Yes. He assigned a fellow by the way who is a terrific musician named Robert Mercy who wrote for Andy Williams and other artists, I mean a really good musician. But to give him the job of producing a Mongo album, we all were like what? You know and sure enough he chose material that was not typically Mongo material and tried to make it into something commercial and it just, as far as we were concerned, it just didn't work. I'm trying to think of the name of the song, I can't think of it, but [scats]

MR: "In the Mood"?

MS: "In the Mood" cha-cha. Yes.

MR: "In the Mood" cha-cha.

MR: You know I sometimes use that, that's very curious you say that because when I'm trying to show students what I means to swing eighth notes I'll use "In the Mood." And you know, play it like we know it and then I'll go now what if we straighten out the eighth notes [scats].

MS: There you go.

MR: And it sounds pretty —

MS: I did one arrangement on that album. I did an arrangement of "Walk on By" on that album but Bob, Robert Mercy did all the rest. And as a matter of fact, Mongo, when he signed with them he said he wanted to do a typical Latin album using different rhythms. And they said, "Well no, let Bob Mercy, we want him to do an album, and then we promise that after that then you can do what you want to do." And the second one was an album that Mongo did, I'm trying to think the name of it, I can see the cover, a green cover with a girl's face on it which was one of the most under-the-radar records, it's a terrific record. Really terrific. But they didn't know how to market at that point, they didn't know how to market that kind of an album so nothing ever happened. It's a shame because it was a really, really terrific album.

MR: Back to these Latin rhythms for a moment, I play on occasion for ballroom dancers and they will come up and they'll want a cha-cha and then a rumba and etcetera. Am I correct that the exact tempo is really important in playing these rhythms?

MS: Yes.

MR: How do you memorize?

MS: Well you know a cha-cha, when you say rumba, a rumba is actually a very fast number. But in the American market a rumba was just sort of like a little uptempo cha-cha. But it's not really a cha-cha, it's not really a rumba. Actually see rumba is a — almost like a jam session but a fast rhythm. I did an arrangement, maybe that was even too fast, but I did an arrangement for Larry Harlow called the "Rumbambola." That was taken from a piece that a famous Latin pianist whose name escapes me now, sorry, had recorded. And I did an arrangement of that and it was really fast. But it was a sort of a rumba. Cha-cha was a whole other story.

MR: I recall a dance instructor said, "You need to play more cha-chas like "Billie Jean."

MS: What?

MR: That's what I said. And it was because of the tempo I think.

MS: Right, right, right.

MR: And they would practice dancing to that song doing the cha-cha dance and for them it made perfect sense I guess.

MS: Right. It fit. The rhythm fit.

MR: Yeah. By the way were all these arrangements you've done over the years, did you copy your own parts?

MS: At first I did. But I reached a certain point at which it drove me crazy and I said once I finish it the way I do an arrangement is I do the whole arrangement. Then I go back to the very top and go through it again checking every little thing. After that I don't want to see those notes for a little while. So at this point I don't do any copying. As a matter of fact, I'm still in the dinosaur stage where I don't have Finale or you know one of those writing programs so when I do an arrangement it costs the people some extra money because they have to have it copied. But like I said, so far they'll accept that.

MR: Some things keep working, Marty.

MS: Yeah.

MR: Pencil and paper. And do you have trouble finding score paper these days?

MS: Yes. Yes. I bought a whole bunch at one point so I've got some that'll work. But if I have to get some more I'm going to have to get some better, larger than I would want but that will at least fit the instrumentation that I need.

MR: I see. And do you write your scores in concert pitch or do you transpose them as you go?

MS: Transposed. Because that's the way I learned. The summer of '58, my freshman year of when I worked in the Catskills, my good friend Bobby Porcelli used to write out a lot of the parts and sometimes to make things easier he would just tell me, "Well here's what the trumpet plays" and I would write that out. So from the beginning I automatically learned to write things out in the keys that the players were going to play in.

MR: So you go to measure four, beat three and you can look down what you did for the horns on beat three and there's perhaps three different keys going on.

MS: Right.

MR: But you can hear it if it's right.

MS: Yeah. Yeah. You know doing it for that long a time you get to know what the notes sound like so it's not a problem.

MR: Well I have just enjoyed this conversation so much.

MS: So have I.

MR: You're a wealth of — I mean I'm like — arranging to me is, I don't have the adjective for it but it's a wonderful occupation and it's something that I think keeps your brain cells moving.

MS: Yes. You're right. I mean you know the way I look at it is you're faced with a blank piece of paper and now you've got to put notes, you've got to put things on there that are going to sound nice. So it's a very inventive process. So I still, I'm still just as enthused whenever there's another arrangement that comes about, figuring how I'm going to go

MR: I think it's a craft that all the music you've heard in your life can come out in your arrangements. And that, there's something about that that makes it worthwhile, even the bad gigs you've played or the Catskills gigs, it's still in there and becomes useful.

MS: Yeah. Well the way I explain it to someone who asks about how do you do that, what I tell them is that in the course of your life you're listening all the time and think of it as learning a language. When you're a kid and you're learning a language first you've got to learn what the letters stand for, and as you develop, as your vocabulary develops you can speak more clearly and be understood more. Well it's the same with music. As you learn the sounds that you have, that you hear throughout your life, not only just listening to records and music, but just sounds in general, it all becomes part of your musical vocabulary so that after a while you can speak more clearly and it's easier to understand what you're saying.

MR: Well said. And on that note I'm going to thank you again for your time and congratulate you on your career again. You're one of those people sort of on both sides of the glass, and sometimes the real architect behind the sounds. So thank you for that.

MS: Oh you're welcome. It's been a pleasure. It really has, Monk.

MR: Thanks a lot. I'm going to pause our recording and then we'll say our good-byes.

MS: Okay. Should I hit leave message?

MR: Let me just pause.

MS: I mean leave meeting?